HM1.4 LIVING ARRANGEMENTS BY AGE GROUPS

Definitions and methodology

People's living arrangements change over the life cycle. In many countries, when young people move out of their parents' home, they may share a dwelling with others before setting up their own home to move in with a partner and/or to start a family. At the same time, when young people leave home, older parents sometimes downsize as household size has diminished. Living arrangements may also be affected by changing family trends and structures, such as increased life expectancy, marriage at later ages and higher divorce rates (see OECD Family Database).

This indicator shows how living arrangements vary across age groups, with a particular focus on young people (aged 15 to 29; for some indicators, aged 20 to 29) and seniors (65 and older). The data are based on household survey microdata and concern population-level data. They exclude group accommodations, such as nursing homes, hospitals, and military quarters. Data in this indicator refer to private households.

Key findings

Less than half of the population, no matter the country or age group, live on their own, with the exception of Lithuania, where 54% of people aged 65 years and over live alone (see Figure HM1.4.1 and online worksheet HM1.4.A1 for earlier years). The share of one-person households ranges from 54% among seniors in Lithuania to around 1% among young people (age 15-29) in Croatia, Mexico and the Slovak Republic.

In most countries, the share of one-person households increases with age. Seniors are more likely to live alone than any other age group (ranging from 11% of all seniors in the Slovak Republic to 54% in Lithuania), followed by people aged 50 to 64 years (from 5% in the Slovak Republic to 35% in Lithuania). Meanwhile, the share of single-person households among 30- to 49-year-olds ranges from 2% in the Slovak Republic to 23% in Finland. In 29 countries, fewer than 10% of young people aged 15-29 years old live on their own – and the share is less than 5% in 18 of these countries. This is not the case, however, in the Nordic countries and the Netherlands, where between one-fifth and one-third of youth live alone.

This document, as well as any data and any map included herein, are without prejudice to the status of or sovereignty over any territory, to the delimitation of international frontiers and boundaries and to the name of any territory, city or area.

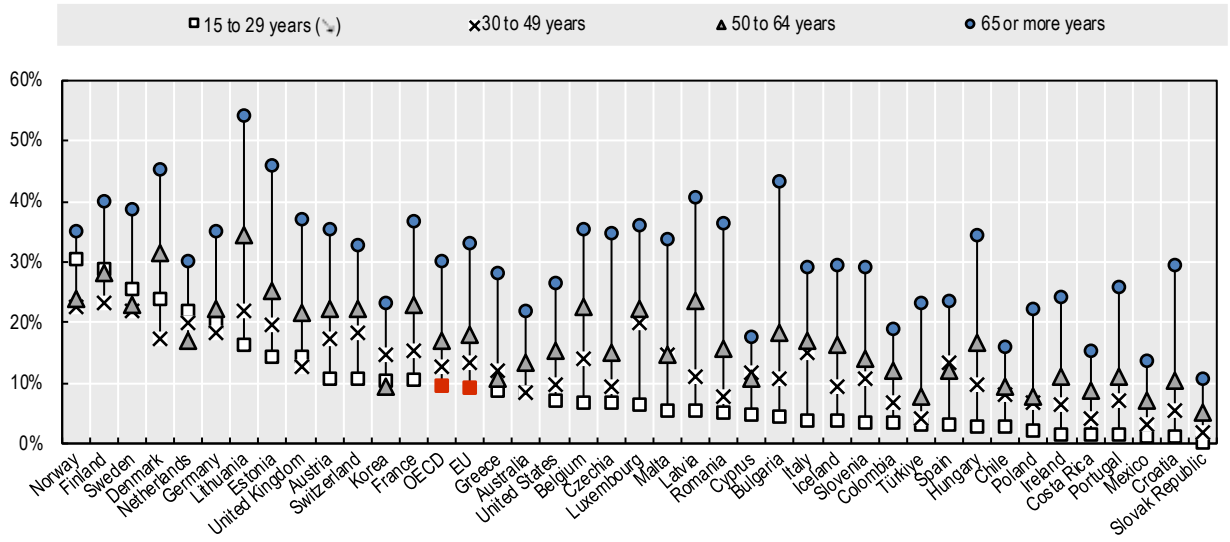
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Figure HM1.4.1. Share of population living alone

Percentage of population living in single-person households, by age groups, 2024 or latest year available



Note: 1. Only private households are considered.
2. No data available for Japan, Israel and New Zealand due to data limitations.
3. Data for Hungary, Korea, Switzerland and the United States refer to 2023; data for Canada, Chile, Mexico and the United Kingdom refer to 2022; data for Australia refer to 2021; data for Iceland and Türkiye refer to 2020.
Source: OECD calculations based on the European Survey on Income and Living Conditions (EU-SILC 2024), except for Hungary and Switzerland (2023) and Iceland (2020); the Household, Income and Labour Dynamics Survey (HILDA) for Australia (2021); the Canada Income Survey (CIS 2022); the Encuesta de Caracterización Socioeconómica Nacional (CASEN) for Chile (2022); the Gran Encuesta Integrada de Hogares (GEIH) for Colombia (2024); the Encuesta Nacional de Hogares (ENAHO) for Costa Rica (2024); Korean Labour and Income Panel Study (KLIPS) for Korea (2023); the Encuesta Nacional de Ingresos y Gastos de los Hogares (ENIGH) for Mexico (2022); Türkiye-National SILC (2020); Understanding Society - The UK Household Longitudinal Study (2022); the American Community Survey (ACS) for the United States (2023).

Living arrangements of young people aged 20-29 years old vary widely across OECD (Figure HM1.4.2). On average across the OECD, around half of young people live with their parents, yet there are large cross-country differences. The share is much larger in Italy, Korea and Spain, where more than 75% of youth live with their parents. Meanwhile, young people are much less likely to live with their parents in Nordic countries, and much more likely to live on their own. On average in the OECD, around one quarter of young people live with a partner, though there are large variations across countries, ranging from 2% in Korea to 42% in Finland.

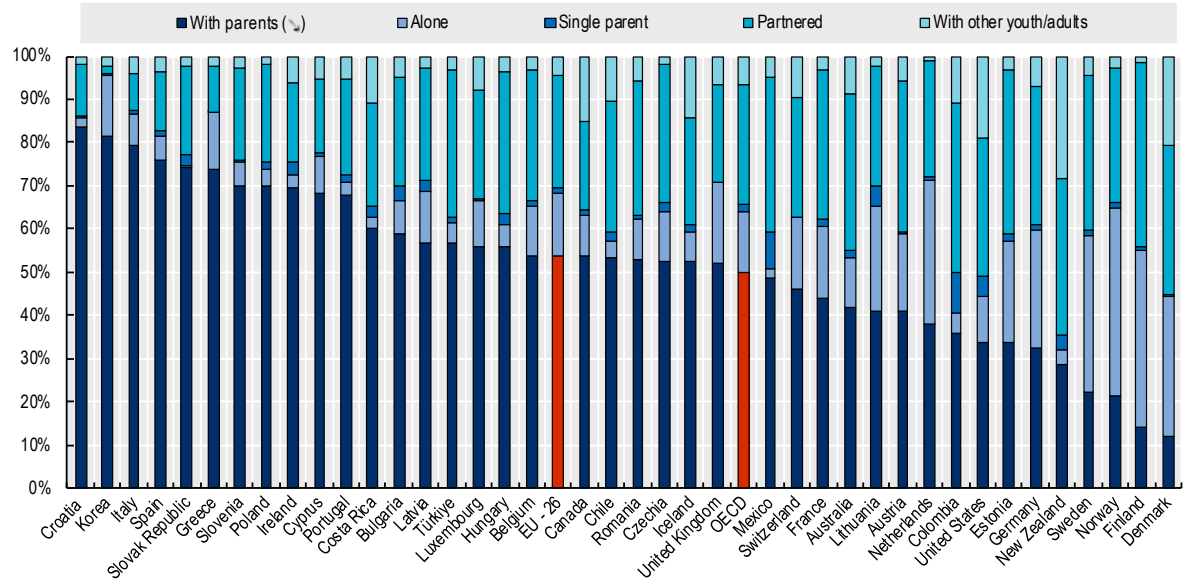
Note by the Republic of Türkiye: The information in this document with reference to "Cyprus" relates to the southern part of the Island. There is no single authority representing both Turkish and Greek Cypriot people on the Island. Türkiye recognises the Turkish Republic of Northern Cyprus (TRNC). Until a lasting and equitable solution is found within the context of the United Nations, Türkiye shall preserve its position concerning the "Cyprus issue".

Note by all the European Union Member States of the OECD and the European Union: The Republic of Cyprus is recognised by all members of the United Nations with the exception of Türkiye. The information in this document relates to the area under the effective control of the Government of the Republic of Cyprus.

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Figure HM1.4.2. Living arrangements of youth

Distribution of young people (20- to 29-year-olds), by household type, 2024 or latest year available[1,2]



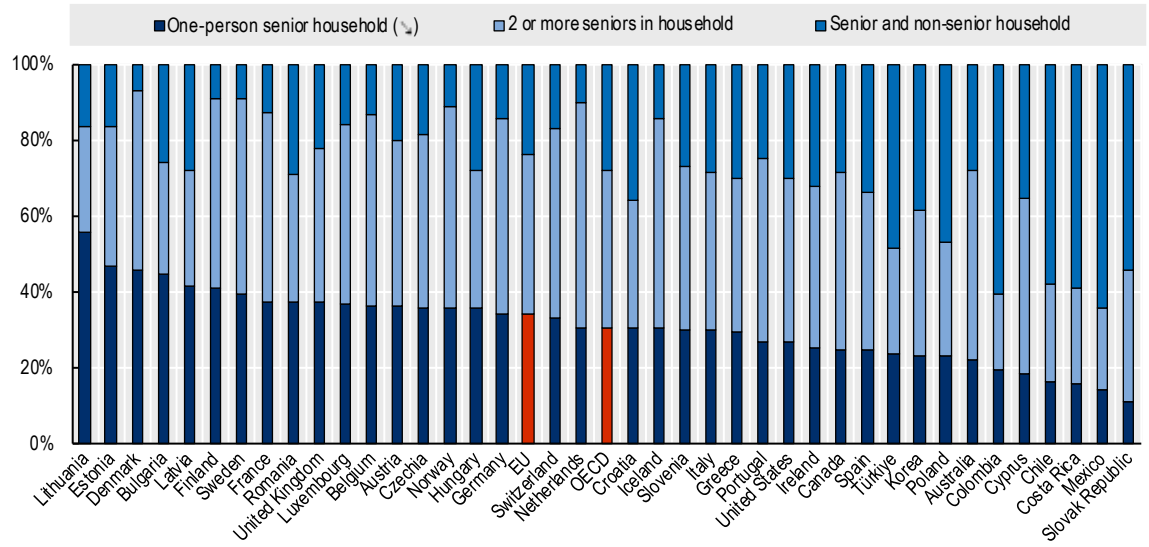
Note: 1. The 'single parent' category includes any individual who is living with their child and without a partner, whether they live by themselves, with their parents or with roommates. Similarly, the 'with a partner' category includes anyone who lives with a partner, whether or not they are living by themselves, with parents or with roommates. The 'other' category aggregates the missing categories for a given country when there were fewer than 40 observations in a given category.
2. Data for Hungary, Korea, Switzerland and the United States refer to 2023; data for Canada, Chile, Mexico and the United Kingdom refer to 2022; data for Australia refer to 2021; data for Iceland and Türkiye refer to 2020.
3. The EU - 26 average does not include Malta.
Source: OECD calculations based on the European Survey on Income and Living Conditions (EU-SILC 2024), except for Hungary, and Switzerland (2023), Germany (2022), and Iceland (2020); the Household, Income and Labour Dynamics Survey (HILDA) for Australia (2021); the Canada Income Survey (CIS 2022); the Encuesta de Caracterización Socioeconómica Nacional (CASEN) for Chile (2022); the Gran Encuesta Integrada de Hogares (GEIH) for Colombia (2024); the Encuesta Nacional de Hogares (ENAHO) for Costa Rica (2024); Korean Labour and Income Panel Study (KLIPS) for Korea (2023); the Encuesta Nacional de Ingresos y Gastos de los Hogares (ENIGH) for Mexico (2022); Stats NZ for New Zealand (2024); Türkiye-National SILC (2020); Understanding Society - The UK Household Longitudinal Study (2022); the American Community Survey (ACS) for the United States (2023).

On average in the OECD, around 41% of seniors in private households live in a household with two or more seniors, with slightly smaller shares living alone (around 31%) or in households with non-seniors (28%). Yet there are large cross-country differences. More than half of seniors live in households with two or more seniors in the Netherlands, Iceland, Norway, Sweden and Germany; by contrast, this is the case for fewer than 30% of seniors in Bulgaria, Türkiye, Chile, Costa Rica, Mexico and Colombia. Multi-generational households are more common in Chile, Colombia, Costa Rica, Mexico and the Slovak Republic, where over half of seniors live in a household with at least one person below the age of 65.

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Figure HM1.4.3: Share of senior population living in private households by household type

Distribution of seniors (65+ year-olds), by household, 2024 or latest year available [1, 2, 3]



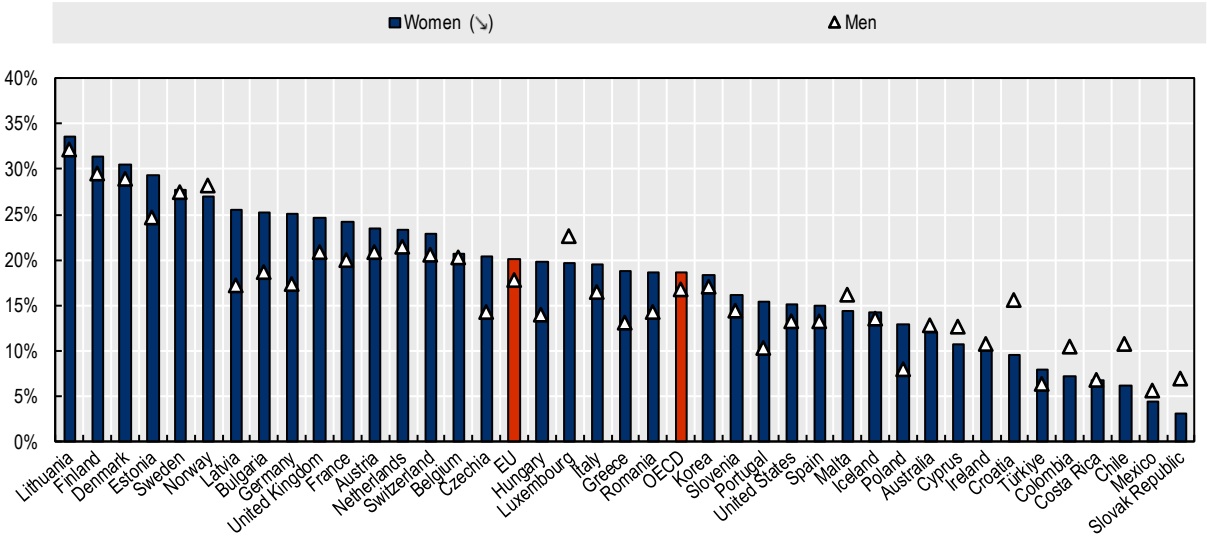
Note: 1. Only private households are considered.
2. No data available for Canada, Israel, Japan, Malta, and New Zealand.
3. Data for Hungary, Korea, Switzerland and the United States refer to 2023; data for Canada, Chile, Mexico and the United Kingdom refer to 2022; data for Australia refer to 2021; data for Iceland and Türkiye refer to 2020.
Source: OECD calculations based on the European Survey on Income and Living Conditions (EU-SILC 2024), except for Hungary, and Switzerland (2023), Germany (2022), and Iceland (2020); the Household, Income and Labour Dynamics Survey (HILDA) for Australia (2021); the Canada Income Survey (CIS 2022); the Encuesta de Caracterización Socioeconómica Nacional (CASEN) for Chile (2022); the Gran Encuesta Integrada de Hogares (GEIH) for Colombia (2024); the Encuesta Nacional de Hogares (ENAHO) for Costa Rica (2024);Korean Labour and Income Panel Study (KLIPS) for Korea (2023); the Encuesta Nacional de Ingresos y Gastos de los Hogares (ENIGH) for Mexico (2022); Türkiye-National SILC (2020); Understanding Society - The UK Household Longitudinal Study (2022); the American Community Survey (ACS) for the United States (2023).

Across the OECD, women over 15 years old are more likely than men to live alone by an average of two percentage points (Figure HM1.4.4). In 27 OECD and EU countries, the share of women living alone exceeds that of men, with the largest gender gaps in Germany and Lithuania (about 8 percentage points). In contrast, men are more likely to live alone in 12 countries, notably Chile (5 pp), Croatia (6 pp), the Slovak Republic (4 pp) and Colombia (3 pp). In a few countries, including Belgium, Sweden and Costa Rica, gender differences in living arrangements are negligible.

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Figure HM1.4.4: Share of population living alone by gender

Percentage of population over the age of 15 living in single-person households, by gender, 2024 or latest year available



Note: 1. Only private households are considered.
2. No data available for Japan, Israel or New Zealand due to data limitations.
3. Data for Bulgaria, Croatia, Hungary, Ireland, Korea, Slovak Republic, Switzerland and the United States refer to 2023; data for Canada, Chile, Mexico and the United Kingdom refer to 2022; data for Australia refer to 2021; data for Iceland and Türkiye refer to 2020.
Source: OECD calculations based on the European Survey on Income and Living Conditions (EU-SILC 2024), except for Bulgaria, Croatia, Hungary, Ireland, Slovak Republic, and Switzerland (2023) and Iceland (2020); the Household, Income and Labour Dynamics Survey (HILDA) for Australia (2021); the Canada Income Survey (CIS 2022); the Encuesta de Caracterización Socioeconómica Nacional (CASEN) for Chile (2022); the Gran Encuesta Integrada de Hogares (GEIH) for Colombia (2024); the Encuesta Nacional de Hogares (ENAHO) for Costa Rica (2024); Korean Labour and Income Panel Study (KLIPS) for Korea (2023); the Encuesta Nacional de Ingresos y Gastos de los Hogares (ENIGH) for Mexico (2022); Türkiye-National SILC (2020); Understanding Society - The UK Household Longitudinal Study (2022); the American Community Survey (ACS) for the United States (2023).

Data and comparability issues

This indicator is calculated based on household surveys. For European countries, the European Union Statistics on Income and Living Conditions (EU-SILC); for Canada, the Census of Population and the Canadian Income Survey (CIS); for Chile, the *Encuesta de Caracterización Socioeconómica Nacional* (CASEN); for Colombia, the *Gran Encuesta Integrade de Hogares* (GEIH); for Costa Rica, the *Encuesta Nacional de Hogares* (ENAHO); for Korea, the Korean Labour and Income Panel Study (KLIPS); for Mexico, the *Encuesta Nacional de Ingresos y Gastos de los Hogares* (ENIGH); for Türkiye, Türkiye-National SILC; for the United Kingdom, Understanding Society - The UK Household Longitudinal Study; and, for the United States, the American Community Survey (ACS).[2]

Data from EU-SILC are also subject to variation across years due to limited sample sizes. Although weights are used to help ensure data are representative of the population, and all indicators in the OECD Affordable Housing Database rely on variables with at least 100 observations, caution should still be exercised when comparing data across years.

[2] In previous editions, data for Korea and the United Kingdom were drawn from the Korean Housing Survey and EU-SILC, respectively. These sources are no longer used due to data limitations. As household survey design varies across and within countries, results may differ from previous editions depending on the source.

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Data collection for household surveys faced additional limitations during the COVID-19 pandemic, which may affect the quality of data in 2020 and 2021 (reported in the annex of the associated Excel file). This included challenges to conducting face-to-face interviews, as well as difficulties to interpret certain questions in the context of the pandemic (e.g., questions relating to the primary place of residence among young people who had returned to live with their parents during the pandemic). With regards to EU-SILC, there were also cross-country differences in how the reference period was defined, as some countries interpreted the reference period as "before the crisis – as usual" while others considered the impacts of the pandemic (Eurostat, 2020).

The analysis considers only private households and excludes individuals living in institutions, such as nursing homes, hospitals, and military quarters. As such, the analysis of living arrangements of older people on the basis of household survey data has its limits. In 2021, across 28 OECD countries, the share of adults aged 65 and over receiving long-term care was 11.5% (OECD, 2023). Despite the avowed political shift away from institutional settings, population ageing has led to an increase in the institutionalised population in some OECD countries. For example, in Germany, Lithuania, and Spain, the share of adults aged 65 and over receiving long-term care has increased by over five percentage points between 2011 and 2021 (OECD, 2023). There are important limitations to data on long-term care services, however. Such data are difficult to collect in many countries, and the definition of "institution" varies from one country to another. In addition, data for some countries refers only to people who receive publicly funded care, while other countries include people who pay for their own care (OECD, 2019).

Sources and further reading

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